

Roman Empire

Seneca was another well known author of an encyclopaedia of science. Horace in his *Odes* developed a philosophy that combined Epicurean justification of pleasure with Stoic bravery in the face of trouble. Livy was more a prose stylist than a historian. The best known historian was Tacitus. Virgil's *Aeneid* glorified Roman imperialism. The Roman law attained its highest stage of development during the Principate.



Colosseum

After the death of Augustus in 14 AD (CE) Rome had few enlightened and capable rulers. With the exceptions of **Trajan** (98–117), **Antoninus** Pius (138–161) and **Marcus Aurelius** (161–180), all others were tyrants. Marcus Aurelius stands apart from all others. As a philosopher, he authored many books. He was the first Roman Emperor to send an embassy to China and establish contact with an Asian power.

External Invasions and the Decline of Roman Empire

The empire, facing threats from "barbarian incursions," depended on expensive mercenary armies. In AD (CE) 330 the centre of the empire moved from Italy to the Greek speaking city of Byzantium. But it was difficult to rule the western parts from such a distance. In 410 A.D. (C.E.) the Goth Alaric led his forces to sack Rome. The Frank Clovis took control of Gaul. The Ostrogoth Theodoric proclaimed himself the emperor of Rome. The final onslaught came from Vandals. In 476 A.D. (C.E.), disgusted by the rule of Emperor Romulus Augustus, the Roman army led by Odovacer revolted and deposed him. This marked the end of Western Roman Empire.

9th_History_Unit_5_EM.indd 70 08-04-2022 10:43:23